Agents and Partners

> **Read this before you promise anything to an agent.** The agent portal is a scaffold in this release, not a working portal. This chapter says exactly what exists today, how to work with your agent network in the meantime, and what the portal will be when it ships.

What exists today

The route exists and is correctly scoped. An agent contact who signs in sees only jobs where their own partner record is named on the shipment — and that scoping is enforced by the database, as one arm of the same policy that separates your branches. It is not an application that was bolted on and then filtered.

The screen itself is a placeholder. It says *"Assigned shipments — shipments where you are named as a partner, and open rate requests"* and shows nothing else. RFQ dispatch, agents responding to rate requests, agents posting milestones and documents, and compliance self-service are **in delivery**, not shipped.

So: do not give an agent a login yet. An agent who signs in and finds an empty screen has learned something about you that is hard to unlearn. Wait until it ships.

The reason it was left this way rather than mocked up is worth knowing, because it is the same reason the rest of this manual is blunt about gaps: a portal that requires real agents to log in and respond cannot be demonstrated convincingly with fake data, so it was scoped correctly and left honest rather than filled in.

How to work with agents today

Everything below is live, and it is the part that carries the operational weight.

The partner register

Network → Partners & agents. Agents, hauliers and carriers, with their contacts (*People there*), the lanes they cover (*Where they go*), their papers, and their account with you.

Keep three things true:

Both names. English and Arabic — they appear on documents.

The lanes they cover. A partner with no lanes recorded is never suggested for a quote.

Compliance documents and their expiry dates. Trade licence, insurance, whatever your jurisdiction requires. **An expiry date that is not maintained is worse than no register**, because it produces confidence that is not warranted, and the moment it surfaces is during an audit rather than during a job.

Until the compliance expiry reminders ship, this needs a diary entry: review the register monthly and chase what expires in the next sixty days.

Naming an agent on a shipment

Engage a partner on the shipment — the role they play and their own reference. That is what makes the job visible to their contacts when the portal ships — and today it is what makes your own operations board show who is handling the other end, and what a supplier's bill is matched against.

Do it at booking, not at the point something goes wrong. A shipment with no partner named is one where the answer to *"who is our agent at destination?"* lives in somebody's memory.

Agent tariffs

An agent's rates go in as a **buy** rate card belonging to that partner. Load them once and every quotation on those lanes prices from a contract rather than from a search of somebody's mailbox.

A spreadsheet from an agent goes through **Network → Bulk import** — choose *Rate cards*, direction *Buy*, and the partner it belongs to. Every line is checked before anything is written, and if one line fails, nothing is imported.

A card will be rejected for overlapping an existing card on the same lane. That is the protection working: two overlapping cards on one lane cannot exist in this system. Fix the validity dates on one of them.

Rate requests, in the meantime

Send them the way you send them today — email, WhatsApp, the phone. When the answer comes back, put it in as a buy rate card with the validity the agent quoted. That way the next quotation on that lane prices itself, and the request does not have to be repeated in six weeks.

The agent's bills, and the account between you

When an agent bills you, the coordinator holding the file captures it under **Finance → Payables** — or reads it from the scan — and matches each line to the cost on the job. Finance approves it with the variance in front of them, and pays it.

Where the same agent also pays you, link them on their partner page to the customer record they invoice you as — *Current account* — and **Finance → Settlements** nets both sides of the period into one figure. See `04-finance.md`.

Milestones and documents from the far end

Your coordinator enters them. When an agent emails a milestone date or a document, it gets entered against the shipment the same day — see `01-coordinator.md`. Mail that quotes your own shipment reference joins that shipment's thread on arrival, if the mailbox it reached is one your administrator has connected.

The same day, not the same week. Your customer's tracking page is only as current as the last date somebody entered, and an agent's update sitting in a mailbox is a customer ringing you to ask a question the system could have answered.

What the portal will be

When it ships, an agent contact will sign in and see:

Assigned shipments	Jobs where their partner is named — already scoped correctly today
Rate requests	RFQs you have sent them, with responses coming back into your comparison

Rate-card upload	Their tariff, loaded by them, checked the same way your imports are
Milestone and document posting	The far end updating the shipment directly
Compliance self-service	Their own licences and expiry dates, maintained by them

The last one is the quiet win: the compliance register stops being something you chase and becomes something they maintain.

Ask your supplier which release, and get the answer in writing. If you are being told "soon", ask again.

What to tell an agent who asks

> "We have a portal coming where you will see your assigned shipments, respond to rate requests and post milestones directly. It is not open yet and we will tell you when it is. Until then, nothing changes at your end — send us what you send us today."

Do not promise a date you were not given in writing.